

Roman discipline
With their gleaming helmets and armour, the well-drilled Roman legionaries of the late 1st century CE were a force that was more than a match for the various enemies that threatened the borders of their empire.

forces would appear wherever complex societies evolved – from the Nile valley to the Indus valley and China. These armies introduced for the first time the distinction between fighting men and civilians – and between different kinds of fighting man. Forces developed command structures and variously armed troops were assigned different roles on the battlefield. By the time the armies of the Egyptian New Kingdom (1552–1069 BCE) or of the Assyrian Empire (c.1000–600 BCE) were marching around the eastern Mediterranean, a familiar distinction had emerged between noble or royal warriors on the one hand – typically fighting in chariots or on horseback and bragging of their heroic deeds – and a reluctant mass of foot soldiers stoically enduring military service.

As powerful states developed empires, their armies also became variegated by the inclusion of forces from diverse ethnic groups. These graded seamlessly from mercenary bands earning a living by marketing their military skills to forces supplied by states that had been conquered by and owed tribute to the imperial power. According to the Greek historian Herodotus, the army of the Persian Empire in the 5th century BCE included soldiers of 35 different nationalities, each ethnic contingent employing its own typical weaponry and tactics. The Carthaginian army with which Hannibal invaded Italy across the Alps in 218 BCE was also an accummulation of armed bands, from North African cavalry to Iberian stone-slingers.

CITIZEN-SOLDIERS

The rise of the Greek city-states from the 6th century BCE brought an alternative to the dichotomy between the heroic aristocratic warrior and the faceless foot soldier, with the concept of the highly motivated citizen-soldier.

The Greeks were culturally familiar with the notion of the individualistic high-status warrior because of their legend of the Trojan Wars, which was fixed by the 8th century BCE and centred on single combat between the heroes of the two sides. But the city-states developed a system of collective heroism, in which war service was one of the duties and privileges of citizenship. Citizens fought as heavy infantrymen, or hoplites, in a tight-knit formation with their equals, glorifying the bravery of face-to-face close-range combat. The hoplite army was to prove an extremely influential military model, although it was only when twinned with the Macedonian cavalry of Alexander the Great that the infantry phalanx became a world-beating force in the 4th century BCE.

The effectiveness of Greece's armoured foot soldiers was surpassed by the famous legions of the Roman Republic and Empire. Starting like the Greeks with an infantry force of part-time citizen-soldiers, the Romans developed a full-time professional army, while retaining the principle of citizenship as a qualification for service. With its discipline, training, and uniform equipment, the Roman legion encouraged the soldier to see himself as a man with a job to do. Glory and renown were collective, the property of the legion with which the soldier was expected to identify. The extension of Roman citizenship beyond the boundaries of Italy helped maintain the professional citizen-army, but Rome could never do without the auxiliaries drawn from non-citizen ethnic groups. By the time of the later Empire, it was dependent to a degree upon foreign troops fighting under their own leaders.

WARBANDS

The various "barbarian" peoples, who at times fought against the Romans and at other times fought for them in the service of the Western Empire, harked back to older principles of warriorhood. The Celtic peoples of France and Britain valued individual bravery and personal display above discipline and cohesion. The Germanic tribes, such as the Goths and Vandals, formed warbands of emotionally bonded fighters giving allegiance to a leader who was known for his exceptional skill or valour. In the end these simpler military structures proved more durable than the highly organized, well-disciplined Roman army. Warband leaders were the men who inherited the mantle of the Roman Empire in western Europe.

By 450 CE, cavalry were once more a major force on the battlefield. The Goths and Vandals had demonstrated the effectiveness of armoured horsemen armed with lances, while the invading Huns, nomadic warriors from the Asian steppe, had shown Europe the power of fast-moving mounted archers. In Asia, the cataphracts (heavy cavalrymen) of Sassanid Persia (226–637 CE) were widely imitated by their enemies. The dominant warrior of the next era in the history of warfare would be a man on horseback.





